

You improved fast at first, and now nothing's moving

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

The fast progress you saw early on and the flat stretch you're in now run on different rules. Nothing about a flat stretch proves you've hit a ceiling: **it usually means the practice stopped asking anything new** of you.

THE GOAL

Pick one specific thing you keep getting wrong, and make it harder on purpose, instead of repeating the reps that already work.

CHECKLIST

You're about to start today's practice, already expecting nothing to feel different by the end of it.

- ☐ Put away or close whatever would pull your attention away before you start.
- ☐ Open your practice log or last note and check where you left off, instead of going by how you feel.
- ☐ Pick the one exercise or rep that tripped you up last time, and mark it as today's focus.
- ☐ Set the difficulty or speed one notch past what you can do cleanly, so you expect some mistakes.
- ☐ Run that pick first, before touching any move that already feels comfortable.
- ☐ When you get your pick wrong, say or write exactly what went wrong before trying again.
- ☐ If you drift back to the moves that already feel comfortable, stop and go back to your pick.
- ☐ If your pick starts feeling smooth again partway through, raise the difficulty another notch.
- ☐ When you stop, write in your log what you targeted today and exactly how it went, dated.
- ☐ Before you stop, pick tomorrow's target: the same move if it's still slipping, the next one if this one hasn't budged in weeks.
- ☐ If today's session was the hard, effortful kind, put tomorrow's session after a full night's sleep rather than right after this one.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 A stall like this isn't your ceiling. It's the effort level you've quietly settled for.
- 2 Aim today's practice at the move you keep getting wrong, not the reps you already have down.
- 3 A long flat stretch can turn into growth again. Tracked data on long-time chess players shows many go quiet for years, then jump.

Why a stall isn't proof of a ceiling

KNOW

A stall like this isn't your ceiling. It's the effort level you've quietly settled for.

What feels like a hard limit is only the point you decided was good enough, not a wall you hit. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

The flat stretch is often your basic moves still finishing the job of becoming automatic.

Your attention only frees up for the next level once the current moves run on their own, without you thinking about them. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Early progress often feels fast partly because there's far less to learn at the start.

With fewer things left to learn early on, each session covered a much bigger share of what remained. [Source 2](#)

What one session does and doesn't prove

WATCH

A session that feels smooth and mistake-free usually teaches you **less of what will still be there next week.**

Learning conditions that make you improve quickly right now often don't last, while the ones that slow you down tend to stick. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

A tired, rough-looking session can be doing real work underneath.

Tiredness only slows how a session looks. The learning underneath keeps building regardless. [Source 3](#)

What gets it moving again

DO

Aim today's practice at the move you keep getting wrong, not the reps you already have down.

Staying with what already feels good is easier, but strong performers put more of each session into their misses. [Source 1](#)

DO

Protect a full night's sleep after a hard session.

The gain only showed up once real sleep happened, and staying awake longer without it added nothing. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

A long flat stretch can turn into growth again. Tracked data on long-time chess players shows many go quiet for years, then jump.

Many of those chess players' improvement showed up only after several flat years, following no steady early-to-late schedule. [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2011/02/20/magazine/mind-secrets.html>
2. <https://gwern.net/doc/psychology/spaced-repetition/1899-william.pdf>
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5. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4141457/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Practising a skill at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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